



Score Board

Brand	Model	Basic Specifications	Score	Price (Rs)
Microdrive-based Players				
Apple	iPod Mini	4GB, Internal Lithium battery, USB2.0/FireWire, Contacts, Alarm, Games, 102gms	68.04	19500
Creative	MuVo2 1.5GB	1.5GB, Replaceable Lithium Battery, USB2.0, 91gms	60.08	14199
Creative	MuVo2 4GB	4GB, Replaceable Lithium Battery, USB2.0, 91gms	64.43	17299
Creative	MuVo2 FM 5GB	4GB, Replaceable Lithium Battery, FM, Voice Recording, USB2.0, 99gms	67.79	19899
HDD Based Players				
Apple	iPod 20GB	20GB, Internal Lithium battery, USB2.0/FireWire, Contacts, Alarm, Games, 158gms	68.83	22100
Creative	Zen Touch 20GB	20GB, Internal Lithium battery, USB2.0, 200gms	67.42	21599
S-Media	Cocopod	20GB, Internal Lithium battery, FM, Voice Recording, Line-in Recording, USB2.0, 158gms	54.07	18990

controls playback operations. The two volume keys are placed on either side, its main menu is icon-based. Vertical scrolling through menu options is simple, but scrolling through a very long list of songs is a nightmare. Moreover, it takes a long time to load track lists and play selected songs.

The Creative Zen Touch attempts to emulate the iPod by featuring a touch sensitive vertical scroll area. There is an OK button just above the vertical touch-area, and they are flanked by three buttons on either side. The buttons allow access to the menu and controlling playback.

The power button and two keys for controlling volume are located on the left side of the device. Scrolling here is not as intuitive as the click wheel on the iPod. It's hard to avoid hitting the OK button, or one of the menu buttons accidentally when scrolling, and the over-sensitive touchpad just sends you into the wrong menus.

The iPod scores the best in terms of its interface and ease of use.

Performance

For the performance test, there was no way that either the Apple iPod or the Creative Zen touch could compete with the S-Media Cocopod in terms of data transfer speeds.

In the audio performance tests, the iPod was in a class of its own. Listening to music is sheer pleasure on this baby—all the songs that we used in our tests came through crystal clear with no distortion at all. However, at high volumes, the Bass Booster equalizer humbles the bundled headphones.

The Creative Zen comes in second here, though nowhere close to the iPod. The Zen's

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sound quality is very good and clear with no evident distortion. However, as you pump up the volume, the treble overpower the bass, making it sound harsh. The earphones are of excellent build quality, and fit the ear snugly—even after hours of use, you will feel no discomfort.

The S-Media Cocopod disappointed us, and the earphones bundled with the device can only be described as sub-standard. Not wanting to base our decision on poor headphones, we plugged in Sennheiser MX300's and got much better sound quality.

However, there was still distortion at high volumes, and the treble sounded too harsh for comfort—even on the Sennheisers.

Battery life was one major criterion in our comparison test. The Creative Zen Touch provided us with an excellent battery life of 25 hours. It was followed by the Apple iPod at 15 hours, while the S-Media Cocopod fell flat on its face at just 5.5 hours. What's the point of a 20 GB hard drive, when you run out of battery before even listening to an iota of your collection.

Conclusion

The Apple iPod was chased insatiably by the Creative Zen—thanks to the Zen's superior battery life. The price difference between these two products is exactly Rs 501, which is nothing at this level—so you should base your buying decision solely on performance and features. The Apple iPod has been refined over a period of four generations, and has become to hard drive MP3 players what Xerox is to photocopiers. Its excellent ergonomics, intuitive user interface and fast loading times makes it Digit's Best Buy Gold winner in the hard drive-based portable audio player category.

However, the Creative Zen cannot be dismissed off-hand. It looks good, has a higher battery life and is marginally cheaper, but still needs a lot of work in terms of ergonomics and features if it wants to dethrone the iPod. ☑

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BEST BUY
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Apple iPod 20GB

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